

Journal Entry 2 — First Impasse Report

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Due: Before Week 07

Part of: ASN 2: Critical Technical Journal — Installment 2

What this is

An impasse is a site of inquiry. It is a place where the work has become honest about something it could only reveal after you got this far. Your journal entry should reflect that: describe what you are finding, rather than what went wrong or what you apologize for.

Philip Agre called these moments **hassles**, those recurring frictions that just keep appearing at the same point in your work, for reasons that are unclear at first. His argument was that hassles are worth studying rather than just fixing, because they reveal the structural gap between how a system models the world and how the world actually works.

That gap is valuable information.

Four things to address

1. Name the impasse precisely.

"My sensor is giving me trouble" tells you nothing useful. Describe exactly what happens, when, under what conditions, and what you expected instead. Be specific enough that someone who has never seen your project would understand what you are observing.

Vague: "TouchDesigner keeps crashing."

Better: "The Serial DAT receives data correctly for about 30 seconds, then stops updating. Reopening the port fixes it temporarily. This happens every time, at roughly the same interval."

The act of describing it precisely is itself part of the method. You often begin to find answers in the act of writing the question down clearly.

2. What assumption were you making that this disconfirms?

Behind every impasse is something you were treating as settled that turns out to be unsettled. It might be an assumption about a tool's capability, a material's behavior, a protocol's reliability, a body's response, or an environment's consistency.

Name it directly: *I was assuming that _____. This impasse is telling me that assumption is incomplete, or only holds under certain conditions.*

3. Where in your matter-network does the friction live?

Your project is a network of relations: sensor, cable, library, code, software, body, environment, all held together through active labor. The impasse has a location in that network. It lives at a specific connection between specific elements.

Try to identify it. Is it a hardware-software boundary? A protocol mismatch? A material behavior the digital system cannot represent? A timing issue between two parts of the chain? Being precise about the location is being precise about what kind of problem this actually is.

4. What becomes possible now that you know this?

An impasse is also a decision point. Three directions are usually available:

- **Route around it.** Redesign your constraints to avoid the friction. This is sometimes the right call, and it is worth doing consciously rather than reflexively.
- **Go through it.** Treat the friction as an enabling constraint. What does the resistance want to do? Can you work with it rather than against it?
- **Let it reframe the project.** Sometimes an impasse reveals that a core assumption of the project needs to change. This is the most uncomfortable option and often the most generative.

Format and length

Whatever form your journal takes (be that written, audio, video, annotated screenshots, sketchbook) this entry should be substantial enough to show genuine inquiry, rather than just observation.

The evaluation criteria are depth of engagement and honest tracking of what the friction is revealing about your project and your tools.

Connection to the reading

Agre's *Critical Technical Practice* argues for a **split identity** in technical work: one foot in the making, one foot in critique of the making. The practitioner who only makes becomes fluent but loses the capacity to see the assumptions they are operating inside of. The critical foot keeps reopening the black boxes that fluency closes.

This journal entry is an exercise in that critical foot. The question is: *what is this telling me about my system, my tools, my assumptions, my project?*

See also

- Thread: Failure as Method
- W06A: Critique as Activation
- W06B: Collective Critique Session — Format + Preparation